

This archival report meticulously examines the facts, oral traditions, and scholarly evidence concerning the deep identity convergence between the **AbaThembu** nation and the **San (/Xam)** populations, specifically tracking their integration within the Maluti and Quthing highland networks.

1. The "/Xam bu !e" and Thembu-San Origins

Historical and linguistic analysis confirms that the AbaThembu were a fundamentally integrated group, with the very name "Tambookie" serving as a marker of a San-Bantu matrix. The sources suggest that early Thembu groups amalgamated with the San they encountered in the Eastern Cape river basins.

- **The "Tambookie" Matrix:**
- **Quote:** "To the Khoesan, the abaThembu were known as the **Tam'bou'ci**. Unable to articulate the clicks, the trekboers pronounced it **Tambookie** and this form entered the written text." 1
- **Book Title:** *The House of Tshatshu: Ancestry, Land and Politics in Western Thembuland*, Introduction, Page 1.
- **Mixed Identity Groups:**
- **Quote:** "A San group called the '**Tambu'ki**', also referred to as 'Chinese or Snese Hottentots', were reported to be occupying an area close to the Tsomo in the 1770s. These may have been a **mixed San-Tembu group**. (It has been suggested that the term 'Tambu'kis', or 'Tambookies', referred to groups of this kind, while Tembu referred to the original immigrant Nguni group)." 2, 3
- **Book Title:** (PDF) *Sonqua: Southern San History and Art after Contact*, Chapter 1, Page 152; and *SONQUA | Earthworm Express*, Page 152.
- **Thembu Praises as Origins:**
- **Quote:** "Close relations between the Thembu and San are reflected in the praises of the Thembu, one of which is still '**the tiny man**' (Wilson 1979:60)." 4, 5
- **Book Title:** *Interaction between South-Eastern San and Southern Nguni/Sotho Communities*, Chapter 4, Page 104; and *thesis_sci_1994_jolly_pieter.pdf*, Chapter 4, Page 104.

2. The Great Mfecane/Difaqane Migration Loop to Quthing

The upheavals of the early 19th century forced various groups into the Lesotho highlands, where the Quthing district became a critical site of fusion for fleeing Thembu, Sotho, and Phuthi groups with existing San networks.

- **Refuge and Fusion in Quthing:**
- **Quote:** "**San were still numerous in the Quthing District until 1879**, where they lived under the protection of Moorosi... some San had settled amongst the Phuthi in huts, tending their own cattle and sheep and growing crops." 6
- **Book Title:** *Interaction between South-Eastern San and Southern Nguni/Sotho Communities*, Chapter 5, Page 187.
- **Moorosi's Mixed Following:**

- **Quote:** "Moorosi lived in the southern extreme of Moshoeshoe's domain with a **mixed following of Nguni (amaDlamini, amaBulane, and amaZizi), Basotho, and San...** The Phuthi speak a northern Nguni dialect with significant Sotho admixtures." 7
- **Book Title:** *Talking peace, living conflict*, Chapter 8, Page 249.
- **Strengthening through Refugees:**
- **Quote:** "As their country was sparsely populated the **abaThembu were greatly strengthened by abaMbo refugees** fleeing the Mfecane. They were kindly treated and enjoyed the same civil rights as their hosts." 8
- **Book Title:** *The History and Historiography of the Amamfengu*, Chapter 1, Page 33.

3. The Universal Physical Marker: Ingqithi / Inqiti

The sources explicitly identify the practice of **Ingqithi** (amputating the terminal joint of the little finger) as a ritual identifier uniquely shared between the San and the Thembu, acknowledging it as a direct cultural borrowing.

- **Universal Adoption by Thembu:**
- **Quote:** "The **Thembu practised the custom of amputating the first joint of one of their fingers** (Stow 1905: 170). ...the custom is generally acknowledged to have been **borrowed from the San** (Wilson 1982b:106)." 4, 5
- **Book Title:** *Interaction between South-Eastern San and Southern Nguni/Sotho Communities*, Chapter 4, Page 104; and *thesis_sci_1994_jolly_pieter.pdf*, Chapter 4, Page 104.
- **Ritual Definition:**
- **Quote:** "in-Qqit!, n. 3. A finger with the terminal joint, or the two terminal joints, cut off. The custom... is followed by **several Kafir clans...** Stow says that among the **Bushman tribes the custom... was almost universal.**" 9
- **Book Title:** *Kropf Albert and Robert Godfrey K-word English Dictionary 2ed*, Page 149.
- **** friendly Amalgamation:****
- **Quote:** "The adoption by this division of the **Abatembu of the Bushman custom** of mutilating the hand by cutting off the first joint of one of their fingers, are all unquestionable proofs of this **friendly amalgamation** of the advanced tribes of the two races." 28/396
- **Book Title:** *The Native Races of South Africa*, Chapter IX, Page 170.

4. Resolving the Identity Fusion: "Thembu or Bushman?"

The boundary between "Thembu" and "San" identity was historically fluid, with specific clans like the **AmaQithi** functioning as derived branches of the Thembu Great House while maintaining direct San ritual lineages.

- **Fluid Frontier Identities:**
- **Quote:** "Southern Lesotho and the northern regions of Transkei and the eastern Cape are areas in which '**ethnic boundaries**' **have always been particularly fuzzy.** ...situations can be unsettling to minds seeking quick and easy ways to define categories of people." 10
- **Book Title:** *Talking peace, living conflict*, Chapter 1, Page 24.

- **The Qithi-Thembu Nexus:**
- **Quote:** "Principle Branch: **AmaHala (AbaThembu)** Derived Branches: AmaNdungwane; AmaGcina; AmaNdlane; **AmaQithi**; AmaNxongo." 11
- **Book Title:** *Talking peace, living conflict*, Chapter 8, Page 232.
- **Creolized Origins:**
- **Quote:** "hundreds of years of interaction between the southern San and other peoples... and the consequent formation of groups of **mixed descent and ethnic identity**, made it increasingly difficult... to distinguish between San and non-San groups. ...part of the problem lay in the initial inability of the Dutch to realise that the ethnic identity of some of the groups was in fact a **creolized one**." 12
- **Book Title:** (PDF) *Sonqua: Southern San History and Art after Contact*, Introduction, Page 28.

5. Naming Practices as Historical Anchors

Genealogical naming served as a preservation mechanism for ancestral origins. Surnames containing clicks and specific clan titles anchored families to their mountain or San heritage even when politically absorbed into Nguni structures.

- **Preserving Clan Identity through Children:**
- **Quote:** "Their **clan names and the names they give their children is living evidence of their existence and their origin**. To quote just a few examples... there are girls' names like 'Nomazizi,' a Zizi; NomaBhele, a Bhele... These names are one of the means by which the history... has been preserved." 13
- **Book Title:** *The History and Historiography of the Amamfengu*, Chapter 6, Page 130.
- **San Ritual Naming (Moletsane):**
- **Quote:** "They the San took good care of him, giving him a girdle of ostrich eggshell beads which they had made. As a result he became known as **Moletsane, the Sesotho name for this kind of girdle**, rather than Makhothi, his Sesotho name." 14, 15
- **Book Title:** (PDF) *Sonqua: Southern San History and Art after Contact*, Chapter 1, Page 157; and *SONQUA | Earthworm Express*, Page 157.
- **Linguistic Click Anchors:**
- **Quote:** "The **Q click consonant in 'Qwabi'** Qhwabi is a linguistic marker of San (Khoisan) heritage, not a Bantu-origin name. Click consonants in Xhosa and Zulu were absorbed from Khoisan languages through centuries of contact and intermarriage." 24/271
- **Book Title:** *Qwabi Family History | AmaQithi Clan | San People of Lady Frere, Eastern Cape*.